

wide basket of commodities, led by supply side issues, this year. “Commodities remain at an elevated level when compared to long-term averages. This is evident when you look at inflation from a two-year lens. Commodities such as crude oil, soda ash, [and] food ingredients are seeing close to 100 per cent inflation when compared to the December quarter of 2020.”

This has led to HUL, Nestlé and other firms resorting to price hikes or reduction in grammage, which in turn impacts volumes and top line. But given the steep rise in commodity prices, even double-digit price hikes—like what HUL went in for

in December—failed to make up for the rise in costs, leading to margin pressures. That may ease with a normal monsoon and a good harvest—leading to softening of prices of agri-commodities and higher incomes for rural households, say experts.

Saugata Gupta, MD & CEO of consumer products major Marico, says green shoots are visible in the rural market as demand has slowly improved since early-2023. “We have a slightly lower exposure in the rural market compared to most FMCG companies. But the rural [market] is a long-term strategic growth driver for us. We believe there will be some improvement [in



| PHARMA |

Fever Power

The market for anti-flu drug Oseltamivir in India has grown over 3x in the past three years, with Cipla, Hetero and Macleods being the biggest gainers

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA



PHOTO BY GETTY IMAGES

► **IT'S THAT TIME** of the year again when the spread of influenza reaches fever pitch. And with the flu season on us, can medication to treat it be far behind? Data from Pharmrack, an integrated B2B healthcare platform, reveals that sales of antiviral drug Oseltamivir, commonly known as Tamiflu, has seen healthy growth in the past three months. In December 2022, at least 227,000 units of the drug were sold, which shot up to 294,000 units in January 2023 and 395,000 units in February 2023, with a value of ₹9.7 crore, ₹12.8 crore and ₹29 crore, respectively.

The uptick in sales can be linked to the rising flu cases in the country. According to the data available on the Integrated Disease Surveillance Programme-Integrated Health Information Platform (IDSP-IHIP) under the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, a total of 3,038 laboratory-confirmed cases of various subtypes of influenza, including